

A crash course on the OCaml module language

Xavier Van de Woestyne -  **Tarides** - <https://xvw.lol/en>



Thanks to **Stefan Wehr**, my reviewer, for his patience
with my *chaotic approach* 🙄!

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Hannes will talk about it seriously at **5pm!**



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Double mention to Mirage, which was made possible in its early days by the **flexibility of the module language**.



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Why this presentation & warnings



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A very old subject and **a lot of exciting recent work**

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Where I began my
apprenticeship on
the modules

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Understanding and Evolving
the ML Module System

Derek Dreyer

May 2005
CMU-CS-05-131

School of Computer Science
Carnegie Mellon University
Pittsburgh, PA 15213



An **ML language**, **Strict**, **Functional**, **Imperative**, with a
powerful type system (ADTs, GADTs and row polymorphism),
Type inference, **Advanced module system**,
OOP with structural subtyping
and **user defined effect** (as core language feature)
Safe, Expressive and Efficient !



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**Let's talk
about that**

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Modularity

Modularity is the **decomposition** of a system into **components** with **well-defined interfaces** that can be developed, **understood**, and **reused independently**.

Enabling:

- **independent development**
- **reasoning** (structure)
- **reusability**

Using **Interfaces**, **Abstraction**, **Namespaces** and **Composition**



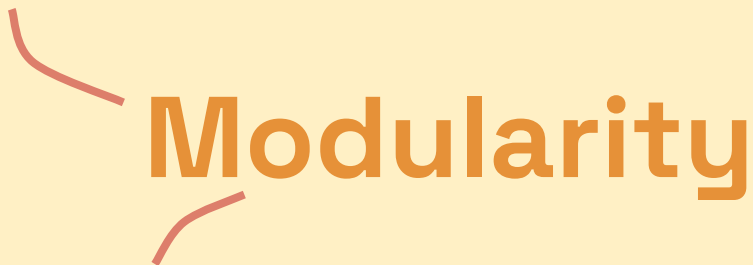
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Modularity

Many different approaches to modularity (in different programming languages)

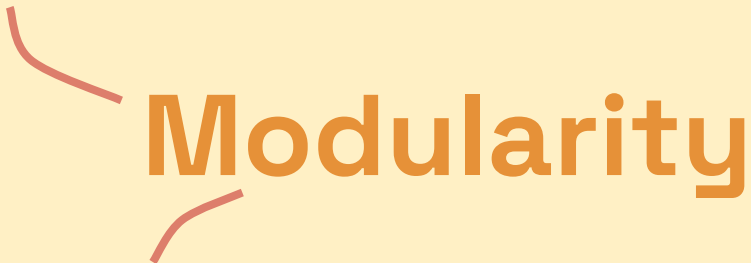
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- Libraries/packages
- Build Systems (*compilation units*)
- Objects
- Type Classes
- Module System

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The **OCaml** (and **SML**) approach!

Modules in OCaml

A module can consist of:

- A collection of types
- A collection of variable bindings
- A set of top-level effects
- A collection of sub-modules

*Can be **sealed** by an interface (without an explicit interface, as OCaml is mainly inferred, the typechecker can deduce the interface).*



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Modules in OCaml

Modules are used to describe several things:

- A business unit/A collection of function
- A data-structure

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Every OCaml file **.ml** is an **implementation** and every **.mli** is an **interface**

This enables separate and incremental compilation (making the compilation of ambitious projects very efficient).

But for the presentation, we will focus on modules as a language and not as a compilation tool.

Modules in OCaml

Modules are used to describe several things:

- A business unit/A collection of function
- A data-structure

A first example

```
module Stack = struct
  type 'a t = 'a list

  let empty = []
  let add x stack = x :: stack
  let pop = function x :: _ -> Some x | [] -> None
end
```

A first example

```
module Stack = struct
  type 'a t = 'a list

  let empty = []
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end
```

Outside of the module, we can use the **dot-notation** to access the module members:

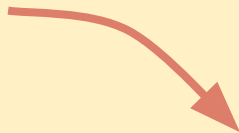
- Stack.empty
- Stack.add 10 (Stack.empty)

A first example

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module Stack = struct
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  let pop = function x :: _ -> Some x | [] -> None
end
```

Inferred into



```
module Stack : sig
  type 'a t = 'a list

  val empty : 'a list
  val add : 'a -> 'a list -> 'a list
  val pop : 'a list -> 'a option
end
```

A first example

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module Stack = struct
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end
```

Inferred into

Our representation is
leaking!

Implementation detail

```
module Stack : sig
  type 'a t = 'a list

  val empty : 'a list
  val add : 'a -> 'a list -> 'a list
  val pop : 'a list -> 'a option
end
```

Let's fix that using an Ascription

We usually split signatures inside `.mli` files.

We **hide** the implementation of **t** making it **abstract**.

```
module Stack : sig
  type 'a t

  val empty : 'a t
  val add : 'a -> 'a t -> 'a t
  val pop : 'a t -> 'a option
end = struct
  type 'a t = 'a list

  let empty = []
  let add x stack = x :: stack
  let pop = function x :: _ -> Some x | [] -> None
end
```

We can also **deal with encapsulation**

(and it is a great place to put documentation)

Abstraction allows us to enforce invariants

Since **t** is abstract, **we can only use make to build a t value.**

(we can also use **private** to make types *read-only*)

```
module Positive_int : sig
  type t
  val make : int -> t option
end = struct
  type t = int
  let is_positive x = x >= 0
  let make x =
    if is_positive x then Some x
    else None
end
```

Hidden in the **API**

An interesting symmetry

```
let f = 10
```



A simple assignment, without
ascription

An interesting symmetry

```
let f = 10
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```
module F = struct  
  let x = 10  
end
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let f : int = 10
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module F : sig val x : int end =  
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A simple assignment,
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An ML language generally includes **two** different languages: **the language of values** and **the language of modules**.

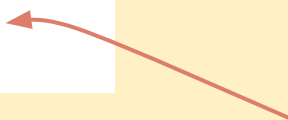
The two languages share similarities (but also differences).

Dissecting module components

```
module F : sig val x : int end =  
  struct  
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A module **expression**

Dissecting module components

A module **path**

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module F : sig val x : int end =  
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```

A module **items**

A module **expression**

Reusing interfaces

One of the roles of **modularity is reuse**. Can signatures be **reused**?

```
module Float = struct
  type t = float
  let plus x y = x +. y
  let minus x y = x -. y
  let prod x y = x *. y
  let div x y = x /. y
end
```

```
module Int = struct
  type t = int
  let plus x y = x + y
  let minus x y = x - y
  let prod x y = x * y
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end
```

As with the language of values, where we have **user-defined types**.

Types can be described in the language of modules.

Sharing interfaces

One of the roles of **modularity is reuse**. Can signatures be **shared**?

```
module type Num = sig
  type t
  val plus : t -> t -> t
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module Float: Num = struct
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The type **t** is now **abstract**!

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Propagate type equalities (can act on multiple types, and modules **with module F = ...**) and can be destructive using **:=**

```
module Float: Num with type t = float
= struct
  type t = float
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```

We can also **recover** a module type from a module to **lift a module into a module type**.

```
module type TList =
  module type of List
```

Propagate type equalities (can act on multiple types, and modules **with module F = ...**) and can be destructive using **:=**

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module Float: Num with type t = float
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In module language, functions are called ... **functors**.

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A **Functor** is a function in the **module level** from **structure to structure**

```
module type S = sig
  type t
  val compare : t -> t -> t
end
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```
module Infix = functor (M : S) -> struct
  let ( > ) x y = M.compare x y > 0
  let ( >= ) x y = M.compare x y >= 0
  let ( < ) x y = M.compare x y < 0
  let ( <= ) x y = M.compare x y <= 0
end
```

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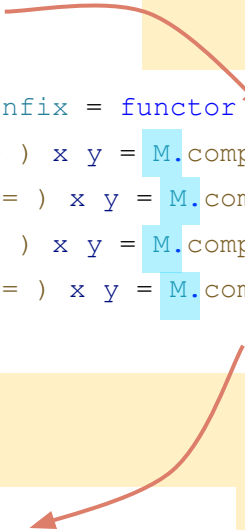


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```

```
module U = Infix (Int)
```

A diagram consisting of three red arrows. The first arrow originates from the 'compare' field in the 'S' signature and points to the 'M' parameter in the 'Infix' functor. The second arrow originates from the 'M' parameter in the 'Infix' functor and points to the 'Int' argument in the 'U' module definition. The third arrow originates from the 'compare' field in the 'S' signature and points to the 'compare' field in the 'Infix' functor.

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Module are structurally subtype
(so we can give a **bigger module**
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module U = Infix (Int)
```

The **U** module now has the
following signature

```
sig
  val ( > ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( >= ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( < ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( <= ) : int -> int -> bool
end
```

```

module type S = sig
  type t
  val compare : t -> t -> t
end

```

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  val ( <= ) : int -> int -> bool
end

```

Functors can also be annotated:

```

module F (A : S) (B : S2) : S3 = ...
module F = function (A : S) (B : S2) -> (struct
  ...
end : S3)

```

can be simplified in:

```
module type S = sig
  type t
  val compare : t -> t -> t
end
```

```
module Infix (M : S) = struct ... end
```

```
module Infix = functor (M : S) -> struct
  let ( > ) x y = M.compare x y > 0
  let ( >= ) x y = M.compare x y >= 0
  let ( < ) x y = M.compare x y < 0
  let ( <= ) x y = M.compare x y <= 0
end
```

Module are structurally subtype
(so we can give a **bigger module**
(a subtype))

```
module U = Infix (Int)
```

The **U** module now has the
following signature

```
sig
  val ( > ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( >= ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( < ) : int -> int -> bool
  val ( <= ) : int -> int -> bool
end
```

Functors can also be annotated:

```
module F (A : S) (B : S2) : S3 = ...
module F = function (A : S) (B : S2) -> (struct
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```

So we have :

- **values** (structures)
- **types** (signatures and module-types)

The next step is obviously: Function !

In module language, functions are called ... **functors**.

(which **have little to do with category theory**, even though there are somewhat ad hoc justifications for them on the internet.)



A **Functor** is a function in the **module level** from **structure to structure**

From structure to structure ? But if I want go
from structure to signature ?



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module F = functor (M : S) ->
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  module type T = sig
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  end
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From structure to structure ? But if I want go from structure to signature ? We can't but:

this example does demonstrate *a little bit* the **dependent nature** of the OCaml module system

```
module F = functor (M : S) ->
struct
  module type T = sig
    val x : M.t
  end
end
```

Functors enable higher kinded polymorphism

Higher-kinded polymorphism **quantifies over type constructors**.

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Higher-kinded polymorphism **quantifies over type constructors**.

```
module type MONAD = sig
  type 'a t
  val return : 'a -> 'a t
  val bind: 'a t -> ('a -> 'b t) -> 'b t
end

module Monad (R: MONAD) = struct
  type 'a t = 'a R.t
  let return x = R.return x
  let bind x f = R.bind x f

  let map f x = bind x (fun x -> return (f x))
  let ( >=> ) x f = bind f x
  let join x = bind x (fun x -> x)
  (* etc. *)
end
```

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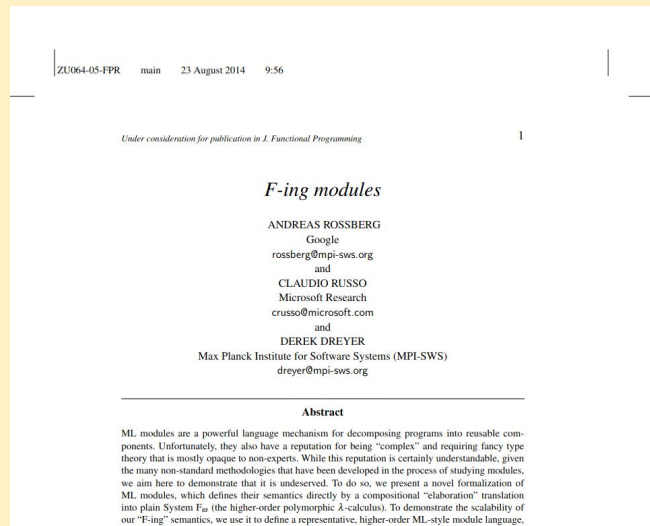
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```

In fact, the OCaml module language is a **typed lambda calculus** (System-F Omega), hence the presence of Kinds (and higher kinded types).



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So what's the difference with the value language?

Unlike value types, interactions with functions (functors) **require type annotations**. This is because, at the time SML and OCaml described their module languages, the theory was less advanced than it is now.

1ML – Core and Modules United (*F-ing First-class Modules*)

Andreas Rossberg

Google, Germany

rossberg@mpi-sws.org

Abstract

ML is two languages in one: there is the core, with types and expressions, and there are modules, with signatures, structures and functors. Modules form a separate, higher-order functional language on top of the core. There are both practical and technical reasons for this stratification; yet, it creates substantial duplication in syntax and semantics, and it reduces expressiveness. For example, selecting a module cannot be made a dynamic decision. Language extensions allowing modules to be packaged up as first-class values have been proposed and implemented in different variations. However, their expressiveness only, to some extent, are syn-

ference [18, 3], and an advanced module system based on concepts from dependent type theory [17]. Although both have contributed to the success of ML, they exist in almost entirely distinct parts of the language. In particular, the convenience of type inference is available only in ML's so-called *core language*, whereas the *module language* has more expressive types, but for the price of being painfully verbose. Modules form a separate language layered on top of the core. Effectively, ML is two languages in one.

This stratification makes sense from a historical perspective. Modules were introduced for programming-in-the-large, when the core language already existed. The dependent type machinery that

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Unlike value types, interactions with functions (functors) **require type annotations**. This is because, at the time SML and OCaml described their module languages, the theory was less advanced than it is now.

But hey, modules can introduce types,
so **we have a mix of types and terms?**
How are type equalities propagated in
presence of **abstract types**?

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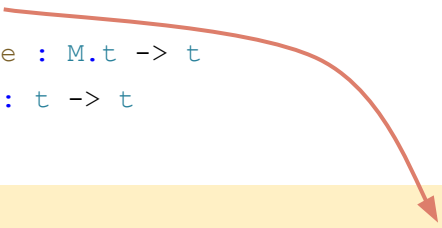
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    let id x = x
  end : sig
    type t
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    val id : t -> t
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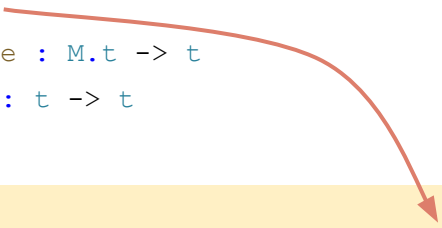
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the type **t** is **abstract**

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the type **t** is **abstract**

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module M = struct type t = int end
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```
module A = Make (M)
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```
module B = Make (M)
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```
let a = A.make 10
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```
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```

```
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```

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Here we mixing **A.t** and **B.t**
Does it typecheck?

it **depends on the semantic of functors**

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Here we mixing **A.t** and **B.t**
Does it typecheck?

it **depends on the semantic of functors**

- If it succeed **functors are Applicative**
(and it has nothing to do with a Strong Lax Monoid)
- If it fails **functors are Generative**

```
module type S = sig
  type t
end
```

```
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Applicative functors:

Same input = same type.

$F(X) = F(X)$

Generative functors:

Every application create **fresh types**.

$F(X) \neq F(X)$

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OCaml Modules

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SML Modules

```
module type S = sig
  type t
end
```

```
module Make = functor (M: S) () -> (
  struct
    type t = T of M.t
    let make x = T x
    let id x = x
  end : sig
    type t
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```

**Become
Generative**



OCaml Modules

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module M = struct type t = int end
```

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SML Modules

But also OCaml if we add **()**

Both semantics offer advantages that we will see in the examples.

Tracking type equalities is complicated

When can two modules be considered equivalent?

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the modules do not share the same path
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use Path to clarify module
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**And also, Applicative functors can hide
generative functor...**

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module A = struct
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module B = struct
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```
module rec A : sig
  type t
end = struct
  type t = B.t
end
```

```
and B : sig
  type t
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Recursive modules **explicitly require types!**

However, there is a little trick that I find amusing!

So we have :

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OCaml allows you to describe recursive and mutually recursive modules, but their semantics are **incredibly complex** because they are **relatively poorly defined**.

I would like to implement this signature by making the three types concrete.

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module type S = sig
  type i
  type s
  type f
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let's use the classical approach

```
module A :
  S with type i = int
       and type s = string
       and type f = float
  = struct
    type i = int
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  end
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  type i = int
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end
```

```
module type A =
  S with type i = int
      and type s = string
      and type f = float
module rec A : A = A
```

It works because the signature completely determines the module's contents

Module extension using inclusion

OCaml allows modules to be included in other modules.

What can be useful for extending an existing module:

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include takes a **module expression** so this is valid:

```
include struct ... end
```

Aside note on strengthening

Strengthening is one of the core mechanisms of the OCaml module type system. It is what allows the compiler to **recover type equalities from module paths**, making the module system usable in practice.

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When we use **module type of** (to recover the type of a module) we **lose strengthening**.

To make this module type reusable in many situations, it is intentionally not strengthened: abstract types and datatypes are not explicitly related with the types of the original module. For the same reason, module aliases in the inferred type are expanded.

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```
module type MY_LIST = sig
  include module type of struct include List end
  val replace: 'a t -> ('a -> bool) -> 'a -> 'a t
end
```

Module Aliases and Opens

Opening consists of making definitions available in a scope without exporting them, as opposed to including them.

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```
module L = List (* I can access to List via L. *)
```

```
open List (* Globaly open List. *)
```

```
let f y =  
  let open List in  
  (* Here, List is available *)  
  map (fun x -> x) y
```

```
let g y =  
  List.  
    (* Here, List is available at  
       the expression-level. *)  
    map (fun x -> x) y  
)
```

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```

```
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```

```
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```

```
  )
```

Like **include**, open take arbitrary module expression.

```
open struct ... end
```

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    map (fun x -> x) y
  )
```

Like **include**, open take arbitrary module expression.

```
open struct ... end
```

Encapsulation without **mli**

```
open struct
  let x = 10 (* x exists but hidden*)
end
```

Module Aliases and Opens

Opening consists of making definitions available in a scope without exporting them, as opposed to including them.

```
module L = List (* I can access to List via L. *)

open List (* Globaly open List. *)

let f y =
  let open List in
    (* Here, List is available *)
    map (fun x -> x) y

let g y =
  List.(
    (* Here, List is available at
       the expression-level. *)
    map (fun x -> x) y
  )
```

Like **include**, open take arbitrary module expression.

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Encapsulation without **mli**

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```

That can **reach Anchoring issues**
Captured by the typechecker

```
open struct
  type t = A | B
end
let y = A
```

Interacting with the value-level

Even though we presented the value language and the module language as two distinct languages, OCaml has **two analogous mechanisms for interacting with the value language**.



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let sort (module C: comparable) li =  
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The module is
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- Allows a form of **Higher kinded polymorphism**

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build **dynamic module based on runtime value**

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let f x =  
  let module T = struct  
    let f () =  
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  end  
in (module T : S)
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The module can be defined as dependent on **runtime** value.

(And we can also apply functor)

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We **pack** (in an existential sense) the **module T**

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First-class module

build **dynamic module based on runtime value**

Val **unpack** a *packed module*

```
module Fs =  
  (val (let kind = Sys.getenv_opt "CONTEXT" in  
    match kind with  
    | Some "in-test" -> (module Test : file_system)  
    | _ -> (module Regular : file_system)))
```

The module is **known at runtime**

Let's look at some examples of how to use module language. For fun and profit!



Let's have some **fun** with a Prévert-style list of module use cases!

Shared behavior

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```
module type WITH_COMPARE = sig
  type t
  val compare : t -> t -> int
end
```

Shared behavior

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end
```

```
module Comparable (M : WITH_COMPARE) = struct
  let ( > ) x y = M.compare x y > 0
  let ( >= ) x y = M.compare x y >= 0
  let ( < ) x y = M.compare x y < 0
  let ( <= ) x y = M.compare x y <= 0
  let min a b = if a > b then b else a
  let max a b = if a > b then a else b

  let clamp ~min:a ~max:b x =
    let small = min a b and big = max a b in
    min big (max small x)
end
```

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  let clamp ~min:a ~max:b x =
    let small = min a b and big = max a b in
    min big (max small x)
end
```

```
module Int = struct
  include Stdlib.Int
  include Comparable (Int)
end

module Int64 = struct
  include Stdlib.Int64
  include Comparable (Int64)
end

module Float = struct
  include Stdlib.Float
  include Comparable (Float)
end
```

 **Less Error Prone**

Data-structures

We have already seen the example of the sack, but the standard library **has several data structures that are already functorized**,

for example:

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for example:

```
(* A Set of integers. *)  
module Int_set = Set.Make (Int)  
  
(* A Map indexed over strings. *)  
module String_map = Map.Make (String)  
  
(* An Hash Table indexed over floats. *)  
module Float_hash = Hashtbl.Make (Float)
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We have already seen the example of the sack, but the standard library **has several data structures that are already functorized**,

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(* An Hash Table indexed over floats. *)  
module Float_hash = Hashtbl.Make (Float)
```



Fits well with extensions and abstractions
(*even with* higher-kinded polymorphism).

Dependency Injection

Dependency Injection

```
module type CONSOLE = sig
  val print : string -> unit
  val read : unit -> string
end
```

Dependency Injection

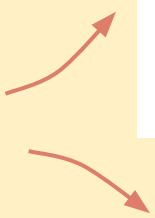
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module type CONSOLE = sig
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```



```
module Program (C : CONSOLE) = struct
  let run () =
    let () = C.print "Hello World\n" in
    let () = C.print "What is your name?:\n" in
    let name = C.read () in
    C.print ("Hello " ^ name)
end
```

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can be simplified using a
Reader Monad (for example)

Dependency Injection

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end
```

But in OCaml, in fact, **we have other tools for that:**

- User Defined Effects
- Objects

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module Program (C : CONSOLE) = struct
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can be simplified using a
Reader Monad (for example)

Packing module and runtime decision

Packing module and runtime decision

```
module type file_system = sig
  val write_file : path -> string -> unit
  val read_file  : path -> string option
end
```

Packing module and runtime decision

```
module Regular = struct
  let write_file = File.write
  let read_file = File.read
end

module Test = struct
  let fs = ref ["a.txt", "A"; "b.txt", "B"]
  let read_file path =
    List.assoc_opt path !fs

  let write_file path content =
    fs := List.map (fun (p, ctn) ->
      if p = path then p, content
      else p, ctn
    ) !fs
end
```

```
module type file_system = sig
  val write_file : path -> string -> unit
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Packing module and runtime decision

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```
module Fs=
  (val (let kind = Sys.getenv_opt "CONTEXT" in
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```

Capability Tokens Generated by Functors

A very simple example of singleton-type using generative functors

Capability Tokens Generated by Functors

A very simple example of singleton-type using generative functors

```
module type CAP = sig
  type t
  val create : unit -> t
end

module Make_cap () : CAP =
struct
  type t = Uniq (* We do not care *)
  let create () = Uniq
end

module Ressource (C: CAP) = struct
  let access (_cap: C.t) =
    print_endline "succeed"
end
```



let's make it
generative

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module Ressource (C: CAP) = struct
  let access (_cap: C.t) =
    print_endline "succeed"
end
```



let's make it
generative

```
module A = Make_cap ()
module B = Make_cap ()

let () =
  let module RA = Ressource (A) in
    RA.access (A.create ())

let () =
  let module RA = Ressource (A) in
    RA.access (B.create ())
```

Capability Tokens Generated by Functors

A very simple example of singleton-type using generative functors

```
module type CAP = sig
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Typechecking **will fail**

Algebraic structure

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```
module type SEMIGROUP = sig
  type t
  val concat : t -> t -> t
end
```

```
module type MONOID = sig
  include SEMIGROUP
  val neutral : t
end
```

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```
module Make_semigroup (S: SEMIGROUP) = struct
  include S
  let fold x xs = List.fold_left concat x xs
end
```

```
module Make_moinoid (M: MONOID) = struct
  include Make_semigroup (M)
  include M
  let reduce xs =
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let fold (module M: SEMIGROUP) (x: M.t) (xs: M.t list) =
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this a pretty new syntax 🎉
before that, it was heavy, with locally abstract types

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```

Since **module-dependent functions** are brand new, we still need to build a library **design culture**.

Tagless Final Encoding

Tagless Final Encoding

```
module type INT = sig
  type 'a t

  val int : int -> int t
  val add : int t -> int t -> int t
end
```

```
module type BOOL = sig
  type 'a t

  val bool : bool -> bool t
  val if_ : bool t -> 'a t -> 'a t -> 'a t
end
```

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module type INT = sig
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module type BOOL = sig
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  val bool : bool -> bool t
  val if_ : bool t -> 'a t -> 'a t -> 'a t
end
```

```
module type LANG = sig
  include INT
  include BOOL with type 'a t := 'a t
end
```

Tagless Final Encoding

Tagless Final Encoding

```
module Eval : LANG = struct
  type 'a t = 'a
  let int x = x
  let bool b = b
  let add x y = x + y
  let if_ pred if_true if_false =
    if pred then if_true else if_false
end
```

Tagless Final Encoding

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module Eval : LANG = struct
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  let add x y = x + y
  let if_ pred if_true if_false =
    if pred then if_true else if_false
end
```

```
module Print : LANG = struct
  type 'a t = string
  let int x = string_of_int x
  let bool x = string_of_bool x
  let add x y = "(" ^ x ^ " + " ^ y ^ ")"
  let if_ b x y =
    "(if " ^ b ^ " then " ^ x ^ " else " ^ y ^ ")"
end
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  let if_ b x y =
    "(if " ^ b ^ " then " ^ x ^ " else " ^ y ^ ")"
end
```

```
module P (L : LANG) = struct
  let program =
    let open L in
      if_ (bool true)
        (add (int 1) (int 2))
        (add (int 4) (int 5))
end
```

First-class modules exaggeration

Let's try to find the type of an arbitrary expression (without type parameters)!

Simplified from <https://def.lakaban.net/2021-06-25-inferring-type-declarations-in-ocaml/>

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type t = (* to be filled *)
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```
let ty (type a) (x : a) : (module T with type t = a) =  
  (module struct type t = a end)
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```
let my_expression = 42
module Ty = (val ty my_expression)
type t = Ty.t
```

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We **Unpack** our module

```
module type T = sig type t end
```

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let ty (type a) (x : a) : (module T with type t = a) =
  (module struct type t = a end)
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First-class modules exaggeration

Let's try to find the type of an arbitrary expression (without type parameters)!

Simplified from <https://def.lakaban.net/2021-06-25-inferring-type-declarations-in-ocaml/>

```
let my_expression = 42
module Ty = (val ty my_expression)
type t = Ty.t
```

And we have **Ty.t = int**

```
module type T = sig type t end
```

This is a locally abstract type

```
let ty (type a) (x : a) : (module T with type t = a) =
  (module struct type t = a end)
```

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```
let my_expression = 42
module Ty = (val ty my_expression : type t)
type t = Ty.t
```

And we have

```
module type T = sig type t end
```

```
include (
  (functor (M : sig module type T module X : T end) -> M.X)
  (struct
    let some_expr () = my_expression
    module type T0 = sig type my_type end
    module X = (val (
      (fun (type a) (_ : unit -> a) :
        (module T0 with type my_type = a) ->
        (module struct type my_type = a end))
      some_expr
    ))
    module type T = module type of X
  end) )
```

abstract type

t = a) =

Here is the author's
version that brings
my_type in the scope

Work In progress



Still an area of research, with recent proposals currently being integrated.

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Avoiding Signature Avoidance in ML Modules with Zippers

Clément Blaudeau, Didier Rémy, Gabriel Radanne

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Fulfilling OCaml Modules with Transparency

BLAUDEAU CLEMENT, Inria, France and Université Paris Cité, France

DIDIER RÉMY, Inria, France

GABRIEL RADANNE, Inria, France

ML modules come as an additional layer on top of a core language to offer large-scale notions of composition and abstraction. They largely contributed to the success of OCAML and SML. While modules are easy to write for common cases, their advanced use may become tricky. Additionally, despite a long line of works, their meta-theory remains difficult to comprehend, with involved soundness proofs. In fact, the module layer of OCAML does not currently have a formal specification and its implementation has some surprising behaviors.

Building on previous translations from ML modules to F^{ω} , we propose a type system, called M^{ω} , that covers a large subset of OCAML modules, including both applicative and generative functors, and extended with transparent ascription. This system produces signatures in an OCAML-like syntax extended with F^{ω} quantifiers. We provide a reverse translation from M^{ω} signatures to path-based source signatures along with a characterization of *signature avoidance* cases, making M^{ω} signatures well suited to serve as a new internal representation for a typechecker. The soundness of the type system is shown by elaboration in F^{ω} . We improve

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Opaque Ascription (current): Hides implementation details and keeps types abstract unless the signature specifies otherwise.

Transparent Ascription: Preserves type equalities from the implementation.

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CCS Concepts: • **Software and its engineering** → *Functional languages; Semantics; Modules / packages*; •

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Adhoc Polymorphism

On the design and implementation of Modular Explicitits

Samuel Vivien* Didier Rémy[†] Thomas Refis[‡] Gabriel Scherer[§]

Presented at the OCaml workshop 2024, September 7

Abstract

We present and discuss the design and implementation of *modular explicitits*, an extension of OCaml first-class modules with *module-dependent functions*, functions taking *first-class modules* as arguments. We show some difficulties with the present use of first-class modules and how modular explicitits solve them in a simpler, more direct way. Modular explicitits are fully compatible with, and can be presented as an extension of, first-class modules. Interestingly, both the formalization and the implementation reuse the mechanism designed to ensure principal types in the presence of semi-explicit first-class polymorphism and OCaml polymorphic methods. Modular explicitits are also meant to be the underlying language in which *modular implicitits*, i.e., module arguments left implicit from their signatures, should be elaborated.

Introduction

The name *modular explicitits* is coined from *modular implicitits* an extension proposed by White, Bour, and Yallop (2014) to provide OCaml with a mechanism similar to Haskell type classes but based on, and compatible with, the module system of OCaml. This builds on two ideas: implementing type classes as implicit arguments in Scala proposed by Oliveira, Moors, and Odersky (2010), but emulating type classes at the module-level rather than at the core-level as proposed by Dreyer, Harper, Chakravarty, and Keller (2007). Using implicit module arguments

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Transparent ascription is necessary for modular implicits because **implicit resolution relies on visible type equalities** to match modules with the required types.

If we have that... we can have

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To conclude



We have seen that modules form a **small language** governed by its **own type system**. This enforces a **clear separation between implementation and interface**, allowing for **namespacing** and **reusability**, while providing powerful **abstraction** mechanisms.

But **Functors can be heavy**

(event if module-dependent function is a clear improvement, reducing verbosity)

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(and that the presentation was not too simplistic).



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I hope we have covered a **large part** of the **OCaml module language** in an *accessible way* (and that the presentation was not too simplistic).

- OCaml is **cool**
- Module are **expressive and powerful**
- The field is constantly evolving.
- With **Modular Implicit**, there's no need to envy Type Classes (*FMO*) anymore.

You should definitely use OCaml for your next project, whether personal or professional!

Thanks!